magazine *Desha Kaala*. *Sakina's Kiss* is only the second of his books to be translated by Perur into English.

The plot revolves around Venkat and Viji, an upwardly mobile techie couple based in Bengaluru, and their rebellious college-going daughter Rekha. The sudden disappearance of the daughter throws their peaceable—even if superficially so—existence out of gear. The events of the novel play out over the next few days.

Using the narrative framework of the disappearance, Shanbhag addresses themes of patriarchy, family, parenthood and middle-class India in a subtly ironic style that makes for a light read, but is profoundly insightful. "Disappearance creates a space in which a lot of things can be examined with a lot of honesty. It's like viewing things through a magnifying glass," says Shanbhag. "It is different from death, because it doesn't have death's finality, but it creates that void and crater which everyone wants to fill because they are nervous about it."

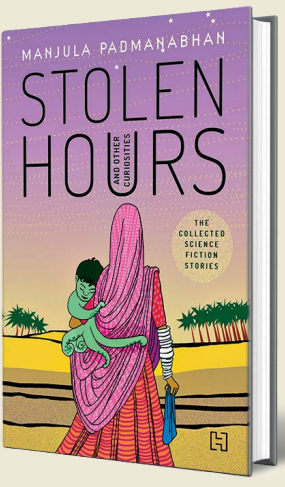
SAKINA'S KISS REVOLVES AROUND VENKAT AND VIJI, AN UPWARDLY MOBILE TECHIE COUPLE, AND THE SUDDEN DISAPPEARANCE OF THEIR DAUGHTER

Masculinity is another dominant strand running through the narrative, with Venkat periodically making ineffectual attempts to assert himself on the home front. "Masculinity and patriarchy are like water. Any crack is enough for them to seep in everywhere," says Shanbhag. Masculinity threw a curveball at the translator too. "There's a Kannada word, *gandasu*, the Hindi equivalent of which would be *mard*. It has a twirl of the moustache about it, but when you translate it into English, it loses its flavour," says Perur.

Translation entails finding creative solutions to hurdles like this that come up routinely in the translator's path. Perur, who feels "a translator is essentially a reader in slow motion", was blessed to have a fair degree of leeway, being allowed to modify and even add sentences where he felt it was required. Translators don't always work so closely with the author and such liberty is rarer still. "You can lump translation at two ends," says Perur. "At one end, you do a really detailed description of what the original book is saying, like Nabokov's translation of Pushkin. At the other end is someone like Anthea Bell [translator of the *Asterix* comics]." He adds: "In school I read the *Asterix* comics, only realising years later that they were translations from the original French. I aspire more towards the *Asterix* end of the spectrum."

"It's not that Srinath translates just what I write. I benefit a lot as a writer through the translation process," says Shanbhag. Writer and translator were in constant touch through the project, Perur challenging Shanbhag at times in his attempt to understand the underlying intent of the words. "In those discussions, he wasn't very kind!" says Shanbhag. "I feel that a creative writer must go through the process of translation, because it is a very humbling experience," concludes Shanbhag. "When you write in your own language, you take a lot of things for granted. When you go through the gate of translation, if you're lucky, you will still be left with a story." ■

Amit Dixit



STOLEN HOURS AND OTHER CURIOSITIES
The Collected Science Fiction Stories
by Manjula Padmanabhan
HACHETTE
₹599; 288 pages

wakes up after a hundred years of 'perma-sleep'.

Padmanabhan, of course, is also a pioneer of comics and sequential art in India. Her character Suki was a mainstay of Indian newspapers in the 1980s and '90s–and then again in the 2010s. The cover image for *Stolen Hours* is one of her own creations. It shows us a Rajasthani-looking woman carrying a dark-haired toddler sleepily resting its head on her shoulders. Except, the toddler is green-skinned and has tentacles. Padmanabhan created the illustration years ago, and it wasn't based on any story in particular. But for this collection, she wrote a very short story (under 100 words, in fact), 'Octobaby', using the image as a starting point. It imagines the Earth being colonised by octopus-like green-skinned aliens who use women to create human-octopus hybrids. Unsurprisingly, these women are seen as 'sluts' and 'whores' by the now-incarcerated men of Earth.

"If you look at the women who were raped/ assaulted in the India-Pakistan division horrors... they should have been supported and cared for, but instead they were encouraged to be ashamed and to end their lives," says Padmanabhan. "Unfortunately, it seems to be a very common human tendency to attack women who're already attacked."

One might wonder why a science-obsessed country like India doesn't have a much larger number of science fiction writers or, readers. "There's such reverence in India towards learning science, towards the power of technology. I feel at some level it's this reverence that makes fictionalising science so unattractive for Indian readers," says Padmanabhan. "The idea that we can critique the formidable power of science, can pull the rug from underneath all that domination; it makes readers uncomfortable."

If you're one such reader wary about approaching Indian science fiction, *Stolen Hours* is the thing for you. And if you're already a fan of the genre, this is a collection you can't miss. ■

Aditya Mani Jha